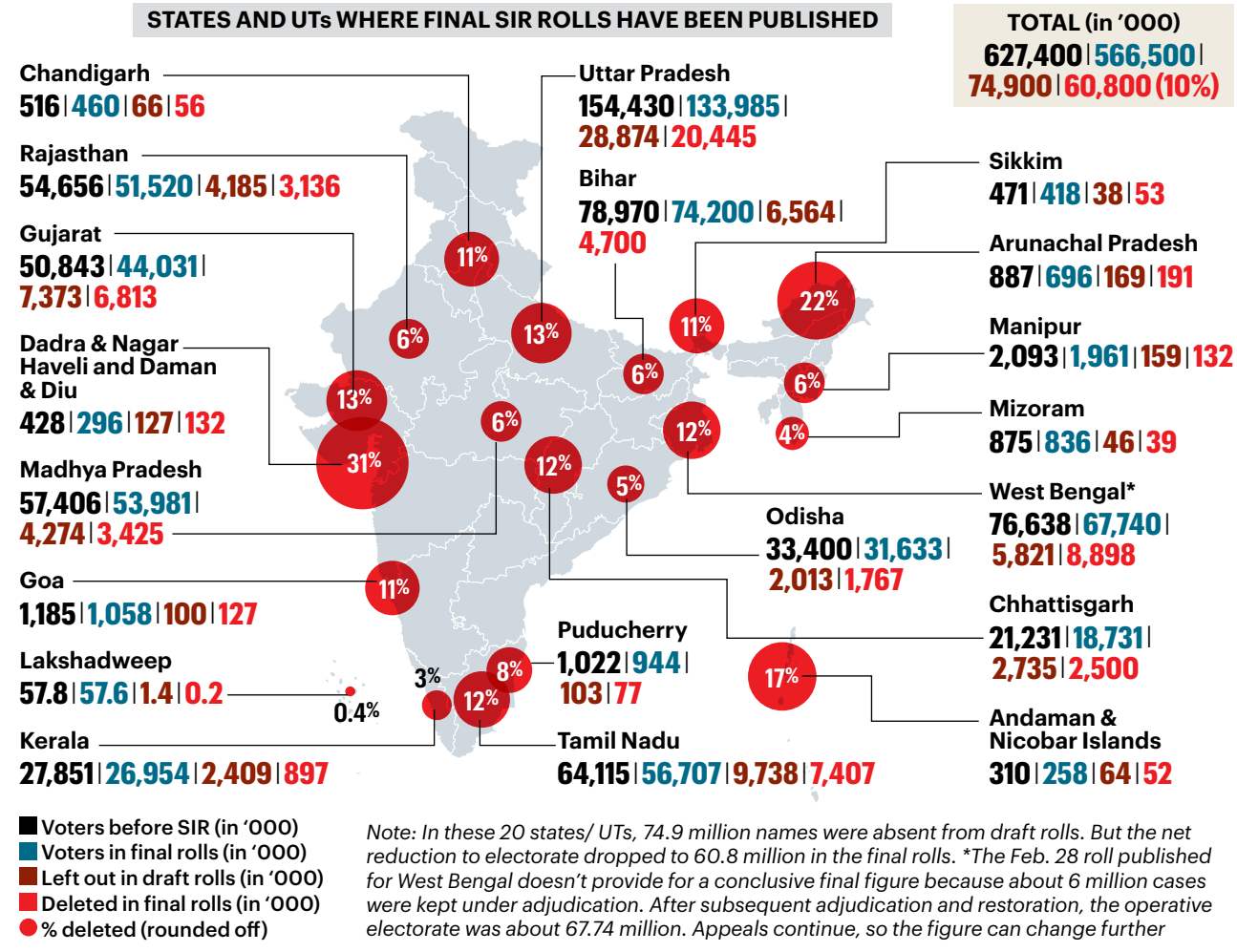
COUNT OF THE DELETED

Number of voters who do not figure in the draft/ final electoral rolls across states and UTs



*Note: In these 20 states/ UTs, 74.9 million names were absent from draft rolls. But the net reduction to electorate dropped to 60.8 million in the final rolls. *The Feb. 28 roll published for West Bengal doesn't provide for a conclusive final figure because about 6 million cases were kept under adjudication. After subsequent adjudication and restoration, the operative electorate was about 67.74 million. Appeals continue, so the figure can change further*

Graphic by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY

filters, apparently, was defined in the public SIR orders.

As a result, in the 15 months since the SIR swept across much of the country, an unprecedented number of voters have been removed from the electoral rolls. Bihar saw 6.86 million names removed and 2.15 million added. That left the state's electorate roughly 4.7 million—about 6 per cent—smaller. Uttar Pradesh's January draft omitted 28.9 million voters, nearly a fifth of the electorate. The state's final roll, in April, still had about 20.4 million fewer electors than its pre-SIR list of 154.4 million—counting claims as well as first-time registrants. Across Phase II's 12 states and Union territories, the combined final rolls shrank by more than 10 per cent: over 51.8 million out of 510 million. In the 20 states and UTs that have published their final rolls till now, including seven from the ongoing Phase III, net deletions have exceeded 60 million. Several big states in Phase III, such as Maharashtra, Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh, Telangana, Punjab, Haryana and Delhi, have yet to publish their final rolls. Spanning 16 states and three UTs, they had deleted over 61.6 million names from the draft rolls. Cumulative deletions at the draft stage stand at 133.9 million. This is provisional: the final figures depend on claims/objections and first-time registrations. As a ballpark, of the reductions in Phase II, 6.3 million names, or over 12 per cent, were deleted after objections, while another 6.7 million electors, or nearly 13 per cent, were listed as dead.

Former EC Ashok Lavasa argues that the SIR exercise reverses the commission's traditional responsibility. "It is conceptually flawed," he says. "It turns the system upside down by shifting the burden of proving eligibility from the ECI to the voter. For 75 years, it was the ECI's duty to go to citizens and include them in the electoral roll. The SIR appears to have changed the priority from inclusion to exclusion."

There is no consolidated national count of challenges. In Bihar, the ECI claimed there were no appeals. In Bengal, citing a "trust deficit" between the commission and the state government, the apex court in February invoked its discretionary powers under Article 142 and handed around six million pending cases to judicial officers. Of these, 1.61 million appeals were reportedly filed in the ECI's name, seeking the deletion of voters whom judicial officers had already cleared.